PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1

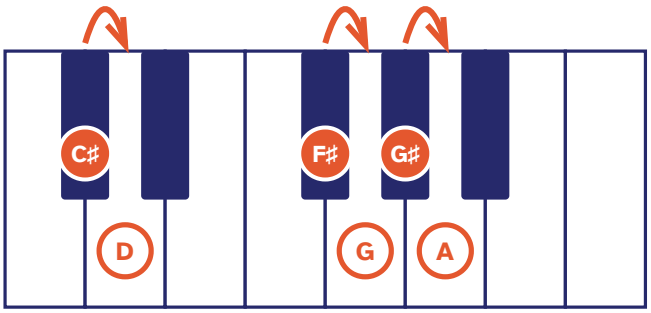
Chords from outside the key

In C major, home is the white keys, so a black key in a chord is a **guest**. Guests never stay: each one moves to the **very next key** (no key between), and shows you where the music goes next.

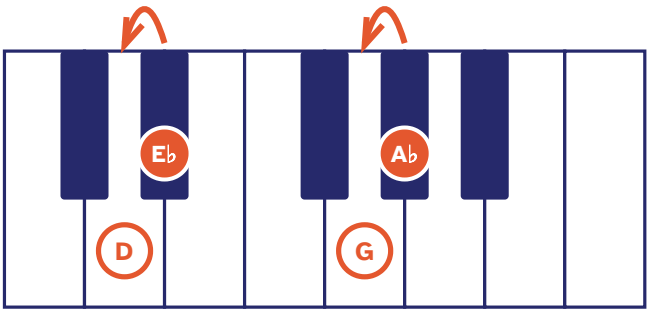
THE SECRET

Sharp guests push up, flat guests sigh down: follow them one key and you find the next chord.

Sharp guests push up

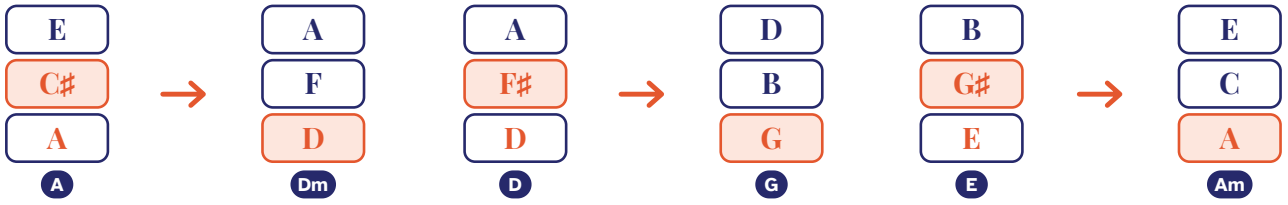


Flat guests sigh down

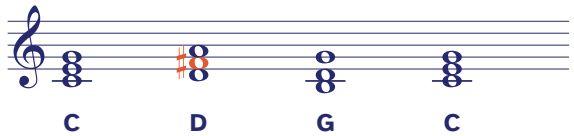


1. Find the **black key** in the chord: that is the guest.
2. A **sharp**? Go **up** to the very next key. A **flat**? Usually **down** to the very next key.
3. You have found a note of the **next chord**. Play it and hear it land.

Sharp guests: up one key names the next chord

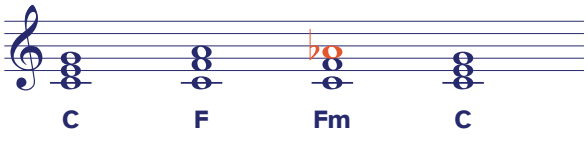


C♯ goes up to **D**, so the next chord is D minor. F♯ goes up to **G**: G. G♯ goes up to **A**: A minor.



Try it in a song: C, D, G, C. The **F♯** pushes up into G, then G leads home to C.

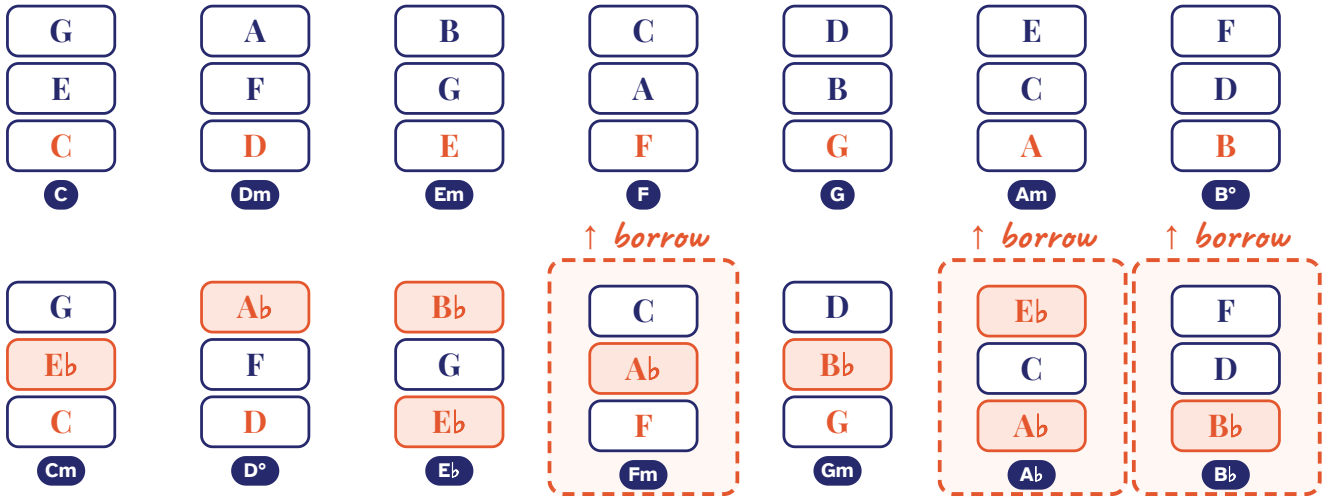
Flat guests: borrowed from the twin, they sigh down



C major and C minor are **twins** (the parallel minor): the same home note, C, in different clothes. A flat guest is one piece of the twin's outfit. In C, F, Fm, C the **A♭** sighs down to G.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1 · CONTINUED

C major *at home*



C minor *the twin: same home note, darker clothes*

Their names, for later

GUEST	NOTES	MOVES	NEXT CHORD	ITS NAME
sharp guest	D F♯ A	F♯ up to G	G	V of V
sharp guest	A C♯ E	C♯ up to D	Dm	V of ii
sharp guest	E G♯ B	G♯ up to A	Am	V of vi
flat guest	F A♭ C	A♭ down to G	C	borrowed iv
flat guest	A♭ C E♭	A♭ down to G	G or C	borrowed ♭VI
flat guest	B♭ D F	B♭ on to C	C	borrowed ♭VII

B♭ is the flat guest that walks **up** instead, on to C (one key between: a tone): the rock and film ending B♭ → C.

EXAMPLE

Where do the guests go? B D♯ F♯ in C major



1. **Find the black keys:** there are two guests here.
2. **Both are sharps:** move each up to the very next key. Where do they land?
3. **Which cake in C major** holds both landing notes?

D♯ goes up to E, F♯ up to G: both live in **E minor** (E G B). B D♯ F♯ leads to Em.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

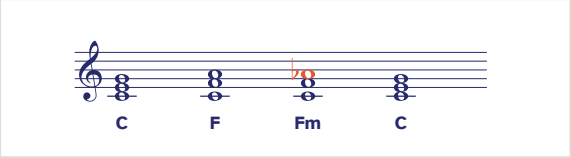
Where does the guest go?

1	2	3
E	E♭	A
C♯	C	F♯
A	A♭	D
A	A♭	D

In C major: find each guest, follow it one key, and write the chord that comes next.

Answer: 1 C♯ up to D: D minor · 2 A♭ down to G, E♭ down to D: G · 3 F♯ up to G: G.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C, F, Fm, C slowly.

Hear the A♭ sigh down to G? Now play C, D, G, C: the F♯ pushes up instead. One sighs, one pushes.

THINK OF IT A surprise guest at dinner: one new face changes the whole conversation, and then everyone goes home.

TRAP

- × Following a sharp downwards: sharps push **up**, flats usually sigh **down**.
- × Calling every black key a guest: in G major F♯ is at home. A guest is a note from outside the key you are in.
- × Learning the names first: play it, hear where the guest goes, then name it.
- × Mixing up the relatives: C minor is C major's twin (same home note). A minor is its neighbour (same key signature). We borrow from the twin.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Slash chords p. 131 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 9 · Online: Library › Chromatic chords